

■ By Priya Sahgal

A book celebrating his life is called *Mohin Kahan Vishram*. A couplet from *Hanuman Chalisa*, this translates to No Rest for Me. While Arjun Singh is not complaining, his colleagues in the Congress say they are getting little rest because of him. Especially when the more learned of them recall the couplet's preceding lines that state, "*Ram kaaj keenhe bina* (My work is still unfinished)."

It is not too difficult to guess the 77-year-old cabinet minister's unfinished agenda. First, he single handedly delivered the Congress its manifesto for the next general elections by pushing through his politics of reservations. Buoyed by his success, he began the Rahul-for-PM campaign. But that was when his luck ran out. Expecting a pat, and some say his own nomination when the actual time came to look for an alternative candidate, Singh was shocked with a rude reprimand.

Suddenly the First Loyalist, known for his Pavlovian response to the Nehru-Gandhi dynasty, deviated from an old script. Last week, he attacked the lack of inner party democracy by saying that the decision-making process in the Congress has "fallen in a bit of a disarray". He followed this up by pointing out that the "evaluation of loyalty is now being done in a very narrow context". This, from a man who claims that one of the two defining moments in his life was when Jawaharlal Nehru rested his head on his shoulder for a brief while in 1960. How many Congressmen can boast of such a historical association with the First Family? Yet, nearly five decades later when a book on Singh's life is released, it contains not a single picture of the surviving members of Nehru's dynasty. When did this great disconnect happen?

Singh's feeling of neglect began with a déjà vu in 2004, when he saw the coveted post of prime ministership bypass him and go to a virtual newcomer, and worse, a man who had made his mark during Narasimha Rao's government. This was a replay of 1991 when after Rajiv Gandhi's death, Singh had been the first Congressman to shout slogans, asking Sonia to take over the party. She had refused and instead given Rao the job. The rest is history. The human re-

THE LONG AND WHINING ROAD

The First Loyalist of the Nehru-Gandhi dynasty is getting desperate as he knows this is his last stab at relevancy



"I have gone through all these things before, perhaps

source development (HRD) minister knows that he cannot rewrite history. But he did embark on a course correction. As he did in Rao's era, Singh has steadfastly bypassed the current prime minister and focused all his sycophancy on 10, Janpath. His cabinet colleagues say that he barely opens his mouth in cabinet meetings, preferring to deal directly with Sonia.

He is one of the few ministers who has delivered—on both the socialist and secular agenda of the UPA alliance. Singh has emerged as the Murli Manohar

Joshi of this government, undoing his predecessor's saffronisation of the text books, replacing the Sangh sympathisers heading educational institutes with Marxists. Yet at a function last week, Sonia ignored the HRD minister sitting on the dais next to her and instead praised the prime minister for his "pioneering work" in the field of education. A lesser loyalist would have crumbled. But a lifetime of serving the dynasty has made Singh immune to public humiliation. The next day, he summoned television cameras to his residence and pledged a